WEEK 5 · LECTURE L1 · UNIT II

# Talent Acquisition and Digital Onboarding

From signal to belonging: how organizations select, and how a new hire becomes an insider.

R K Singh · Senior Professor, Department of Commerce · Delhi School of Economics, University of Delhi
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AFTER THIS LECTURE YOU SHOULD BE ABLE TO

# What this lecture prepares you for

- Explain hiring as a two-way signaling problem, and why validity governs a screen's value.
- Apply the ASA cycle and Barocas and Selbst's five routes to disparate impact.
- Explain onboarding as socialization using Van Maanen and Schein, Bauer et al., Bauer's Four Cs and the psychological contract.
- Evaluate India Stack onboarding and frontline versus corporate onboarding design.

**COURSE OUTCOMES**

CLO 2 (talent acquisition and onboarding) and CLO 5.

ULRICH AND SMALLWOOD (2012)

# Talent is a product of three Cs, not a sum

**Competence**

Can do: the knowledge, skills and values the job needs now and in future.

**Commitment**

Will do: the effort and energy a person chooses to give.

**Contribution**

Wants to do: finding meaning and purpose in the work, so effort lasts.

Talent = competence × commitment × contribution. If any one is zero, talent is zero. A course score measures, at most, part of competence.

THEORY 1

# Hiring is a two-way signaling problem

### The employer reads the candidate

Spence (1973): when quality is hidden, employers rely on costly signals such as degrees and experience. An ATS turns signals into keywords and cut-offs.

### The candidate reads the employer

Rynes, Bretz and Gerhart (1991): applicants treat delays, tone and process quality as signals of how the firm treats people. A silent auto-rejection is also a signal.

THEORY 1B

# A screen is only as useful as its validity

### Taylor and Russell (1939)

A selection tool adds value through validity, the selection ratio and the base rate of good performers, together.

### Meta-analytic evidence

Schmidt and Hunter (1998), revised by Sackett et al. (2022): structured interviews rank among the most valid methods; keyword screens are rarely validated.

### The rigor test

What is the tool's validity against later job performance, and who measured it?

THEORY 2

# The ASA cycle explains why screening models copy the past

### Attraction, selection, attrition

Schneider (1987): similar people apply, the firm picks people like current staff, those who do not fit leave, and the workforce narrows.

### Two kinds of fit

Kristof (1996): person-organization fit (values) differs from person-job fit (skills). A model trained on past hires learns both, mixed together.

BAROCAS AND SELBST (2016)

# Five routes by which a hiring model produces disparate impact

| Route | How it enters a screen |
|---|---|
| 1. Target variable | "Good hire" defined as long tenure, which favors groups that faced fewer career breaks |
| 2. Labeled examples | Past offers, already skewed, used as the training answer key |
| 3. Feature selection | Fields chosen that exist for some applicants and not others |
| 4. Proxies | A career gap or a college name stands in for gender or class |
| 5. Masking | A deliberately biased choice hidden inside a neutral-looking model |

**EXAM LENS**

Naming the route is more analytical than saying "the algorithm is biased".

THEORY 3 · GILLILAND (1993)

# Candidates judge the process, not only the result

| Procedural rule | What a typical ATS does |
|---|---|
| Job relatedness | Does a keyword match actually track the job? |
| Opportunity to perform | Rejected before any human contact |
| Consistency | The same rule for all: a genuine strength |
| Feedback | Silent rejection, no reason given |
| Two-way communication | A chatbot, or nothing |

THEORY 4 · VAN MAANEN AND SCHEIN (1979); JONES (1986)

# Six choices every onboarding design makes

| Institutionalized | Individualized |
|---|---|
| Collective | Individual |
| Formal | Informal |
| Sequential | Random |
| Fixed | Variable |
| Serial | Disjunctive |
| Investiture | Divestiture |

**EXAM LENS**

Jones (1986): institutionalized tactics produce less role ambiguity and more commitment (a custodial orientation); individualized tactics produce more role innovation.

THEORY 5 · BAUER ET AL. (2007)

# What onboarding must produce: three adjustment states

**Inputs**

Socialization tactics and the newcomer's own information seeking.

**Adjustment**

Role clarity, self-efficacy and social acceptance.

**Outcomes**

Performance, satisfaction, commitment and intention to stay.

EXAM LENS

Measure the middle box. Completing onboarding tasks is an input, not an outcome.

THEORY 5B

# Newcomers reduce uncertainty by seeking information

### Uncertainty reduction

Berger and Calabrese (1975): people in new relationships act to make others predictable; newcomers do the same with the organization.

### Seeking tactics

Miller and Jablin (1991): overt and indirect questions, third parties, testing limits, observing. A chatbot serves only the first.

### What they seek

Morrison (1993): technical, role, normative, performance feedback and social information. Normative and social answers come from people.

THEORY 5C · ROUSSEAU (1989; 1995)

# Onboarding writes the psychological contract

### The contract

Beliefs about mutual promises, held by the employee: transactional (pay for work) or relational (loyalty, growth).

### Early breach

Robinson and Rousseau (1994): a majority of new graduates reported a broken promise within two years; breach predicted lower trust and higher exit.

### Realistic previews

Premack and Wanous (1985): previews lower inflated expectations; the effect on retention is small but reliable.

THEORY 6 · BAUER (2010)

# The Four Cs: most organizations stop at the first

**Compliance**
Rules, forms, policy sign-offs.

**Clarification**
Role and expectations.

**Culture**
Norms, written and unwritten.

**Connection**
Relationships and networks.

Passive onboarding covers compliance and some clarification. Proactive onboarding plans all four on purpose.

SYNTHESIS

# Four onboarding frameworks, four units of analysis

| Framework | What it describes | What it misses |
|---|---|---|
| Van Maanen and Schein (1979) | How the organization structures entry (tactics) | The newcomer's own seeking |
| Bauer (2010), Four Cs | What content onboarding covers | How content is delivered |
| Klein and Polin (2012) | Concrete practices: inform, welcome, guide | Outcomes in the newcomer |
| Bauer et al. (2007) | Adjustment states and outcomes | Specific practices to use |

**EXAM LENS**

Use a process framework to design onboarding and an outcome model to evaluate it. Mixing them up is a common error.

APPLICATION

# India Stack: the onboarding rail for a frontline hire

**Aadhaar eKYC**
Identity verified in minutes.

**DigiLocker**
Verified documents, no photocopies.

**eSign**
Offer letter and policies signed on a phone.

**Bank check**
Account confirmed for the first salary.

Every step collects personal data: name its purpose and collect only what is needed (DPDP Act 2023). The rail completes compliance; it does nothing for culture or connection.

DESIGN

# Frontline and corporate onboarding are different journeys

| | Corporate new hire | Frontline new hire |
|---|---|---|
| Device | Laptop issued on day one | Own smartphone, often with limited data |
| Language | English portal works | Needs a regional language, voice first |
| Documents | Email upload and e-sign | DigiLocker, eKYC and e-sign from the phone |
| First week | Induction sessions and a manager meeting | On the shop floor in shifts, with a buddy |
| Success measure | Time to productivity | Still in the job at 90 days |

**EXAM LENS**

Apply Sweller's (1988) cognitive load theory: build the first month as a staircase, one task at a time, rather than a day-one information dump.

THEORY IN DEPTH · CABLE, GINO AND STAATS (2013)

# Let newcomers bring themselves to work

### THE CORE IDEA

A field experiment at Wipro's call centers in India compared onboarding that stressed the firm's identity with onboarding that stressed newcomers' own strengths.

### HOW IT WORKS

Newcomers asked to share what they do best showed higher retention and customer satisfaction months later.

### LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

One firm and one job type; results may differ elsewhere.

### IN PRACTICE

A first-week mobile flow could ask each new hire, in their own language, what they are good at. It costs almost nothing.

### EXAM LENS

An Indian field experiment is strong evidence in an exam answer; note its generalizability limit.

THEORY IN DEPTH · BANDURA (1977)

# Belief in your ability predicts whether you try

### THE CORE IDEA

Self-efficacy is confidence that you can perform a specific task.

### HOW IT WORKS

Four sources: mastery experiences, watching peers succeed, verbal encouragement, and physiological state under stress.

### LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Efficacy is task-specific; confidence in one app does not automatically transfer.

### IN PRACTICE

An easy first self-service task, demonstrated by a peer from the same workplace, builds efficacy faster than a manual.

### EXAM LENS

Link self-efficacy to Bauer et al.'s adjustment states: it is one of the three.

PRACTICE FOR THE END-TERM EXAMINATION

# Questions to rehearse

"Onboarding is socialization, not paperwork." Critically discuss using Van Maanen and Schein, Bauer et al. (2007) and the psychological contract. **20 marks**

**A strong answer:** distinguishes tactics, content and outcomes; uses the three adjustment states; explains early breach; evaluates digital onboarding's limits for culture and connection.

Explain how a hiring algorithm can produce disparate impact without any intent to discriminate. **20 marks**

**A strong answer:** uses the ASA cycle and Barocas and Selbst's five routes; gives an HR example of each; proposes audits.

What can India Stack do for onboarding, and what can it not do? **10 marks**

**A strong answer:** explains eKYC, DigiLocker and eSign; notes DPDP purpose limitation; argues it covers compliance but not culture or connection.

CARRY THESE INTO THE EXAMINATION

# Three things to remember

1. **Hiring is two-way signaling**
   The process signals to candidates as much as the CV signals to employers.

2. **Models trained on the past copy the past**
   Name the route by which bias enters.

3. **A document checklist completes onboarding for the HRIS; only connection completes it for the person**
   Measure adjustment, not task completion.

SET READINGS · FROM THE LESSON PLAN

# Read for this lecture

- Scully-Russ, E., & Torraco, R. J. (2020), pp. 83–84 (new models of education and workplace learning).

**COMPANION**

Each set reading is explained in the matching Unit Reader on rksingh.tech/materials.

THEORY SOURCES · FOR REFERENCE

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Works named on the slides of this lecture. They are background sources, not set readings.


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